

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

Writing Spot: That's Not Funny!



Learning Outcome

Describe hypothetical situations in written and spoken interactions according to work and social contexts.

Ask your partner:

- Do you like comedy? Who is your favorite comedian?
- What do you think about comedians?

Can Do Statements

- I can write about work, entertainment and reactions in different situations.
- I can write about habits in the past.
- I can write about what is being done or what has been done.





Let's Explore!

Everyone has different tastes in humor, but is it right to make a living **at the expense of others***?

* "At the expense of others" means to harm someone or something for your own benefit.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

Location: Laughing Cow Comedy Club

Date: Friday, November 30th

There is a lot being written about Larry Fine and his witty comedy, sharp tongue, and perfect delivery. His performance is being touted as the next big star. With these reviews in mind, I headed down to the Laughing Cow Comedy Club on Friday night for an evening of amusement. Not only did I find his humor to be disappointing, but I also thought it was very rude.

Fine's show is a mixture of insults, racist and sexist comments, and name-calling. Besides the fact that he insults almost every racial group imaginable, he has attacked and picked on vulnerable people out of the audience. Although, this show has been given so many accolades, it represents the lowest form of comedy that exists: cheap laughs at the expense of others. His show is being promoted as something it is not. Audience members have been misguided.

Although many audience members clearly find the show hilarious, others have been hurt by the comedian. I took the opportunity to have a chat with the owner of the Laughing Cow, after the show. He clearly disagreed with me about the show and about Larry Fine himself. His explanation was that, "Larry hasn't focussed on one specific group or person; he's not racist. His show used to be more controversial. He's going straight to the top." In my opinion, Fine has damaged the reputation of comedians. I used to love going to see comedy shows live and would pay a lot of money. What a disgrace!





Let's Practice!

Elements of a TV review.

Instructions: Draw a line to match the definitions in Column A with the words in Column B. Use the words to write sentences. Use the sentences to model a conversation with your partner. Switch roles.

COLUMN A

1. Location
2. Date
3. Introduction
4. Text body
5. Conclusion

COLUMN B

- a. where something has taken place
- b. this is the last part of the text and includes your opinion on what was analyzed and presented, and closes the text
- c. this develops the topic of the review and describes what is being reviewed
- d. this sets the topic you are going to describe and analyze in the review
- e. the time of day when something happened or was written



Let's Practice!

Let's talk a bit about old habits on TV shows.

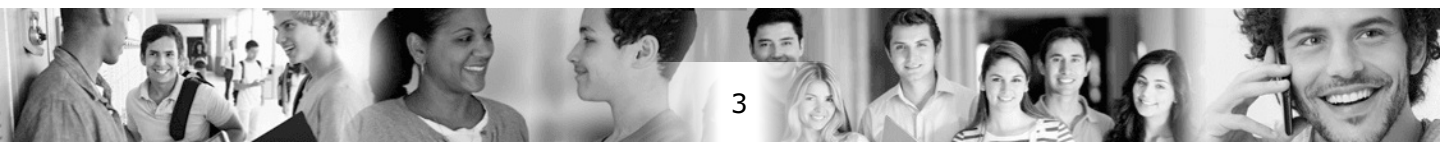
Instructions: Organize the mystery sentence. Read the sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

1. used / His / . / show / more / to / be / controversial

2. I / comedy / . / to / going / love / see / used / to / shows

3. opinion / be / . / used / to / really / sharp / Her

4. used / He / to / . / good / reputation /... / more / a / not / have / any





Extension Activity

Watch someone do a comedy routine in English.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Go online or to the library to find a routine by an English speaking comedian.
- Watch a portion of the routine and take notes.
- Identify the topics the comedian talks about and what he or she has to say about it.
- Consider why the comedian is or is not funny and write down your comments.
- Using your notes, tell another student about the comedy routine and the comedian.
- Explain what has been done to make the audience laugh.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I find a routine by an English speaking comedian.

☐ ☐

I watch the performance and take notes.

☐ ☐

I make comments on why the comedian is or is not funny.

☐ ☐

I explain why the audience laughs using the Present Perfect.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- delivery** (noun): the act of taking goods, letters, parcels, etc. to people's houses or places of work
e.g. There is a lot being written about Larry Fine and his witty comedy, sharp tongue, and perfect delivery.
- sexist** (adjective): suggesting women are less able than men or refer to women's bodies, behavior, or feelings in a disrespectful way
e.g. Fine's show is a mixture of insults, racist and sexist comments, and name-calling.
- to insult** (verb): to say or do something to someone that is rude or offensive
e.g. He insults almost every racial group imaginable.
- accolades** (noun): praise and approval
e.g. Although, this show has been given so many accolades, it represents the lowest form of comedy that exists.
- reputation** (noun): the opinion that people in general have about someone or something
e.g. Fine has damaged the reputation of comedians.
- cheap** (adjective): costing little money or less than is usual or expected
e.g. His comedy is just cheap laughs at the expense of others.
- to tout** (verb): to advertise, talk about, or praise something or someone strongly
e.g. His performance is being touted as the next big star.
- sharp** (adjective): hurtful and angry tone
e.g. There is a lot being written about Larry Fine and his witty comedy, sharp tongue, and perfect delivery.





Learning Points

Present Perfect tense vs. Past Simple and Used to and Would

You use the **Present Perfect tense** to talk about a finished action or event that is connected to the present in some way.

You use the **Simple Past tense** to talk about a finished action or event **not** necessarily connected to the present.

You can use the **Present Perfect tense** to talk about experience.

When you use the **Present Perfect tense**, you think about the past and present together. There is some connection between what happened in the past and now.

To help you decide whether you should use the **Present Perfect tense** or the **Past Simple tense**, ask yourself the questions 'When?'

If you can answer the question 'When?', the past time is stated or inferred or understood. Use the **Past Simple**. There is no connection to the present.

If you cannot answer the question 'When?', because the time is not stated or not important, then choose the **Present Perfect tense**. There is instead a connection to the present.

Past Habit – Used to and Would

When we talk about things that happened in the past but don't happen anymore we can do it in different ways.

You can use **used to** to talk about past states that don't happen now.

You can also use **used to** to talk about repeated actions.

Example:

- *I used to go to comedy shows all the time.*
- *I used to love going to these shows but I have now changed my mind.*
- *His show used to be more controversial.*

You can use **would** to talk about repeated past actions.

Example:

- *We would always sit up the front to get a better view of the stage.*
- *I used to love going to see comedy shows live and would pay a lot of money.*

Examples:

- *Besides the fact that he insults almost every racial group imaginable, he has attacked and picked on the vulnerable people out of the audience.*





Learning Points

- *In this reviewer's opinion, Fine has damaged the reputation of comedians.*
- *I took the opportunity to have a chat with Peter Morey, the owner of the Laughing Cow, after the show.*

Passive of Present Continuous tense and Present Perfect tense

You often choose the passive form when you want to talk about an action but are not so interested in saying who or what does/did it. Passives without agents (the doers) are common in academic and scientific writing.

You use the **Present Continuous** to talk about an action that is happening at the time of speaking. The action or event is in progress.

Passive sentences in the **Present Continuous tense** have the following structure:

Object of the active sentence + is/are/am + being + past participle form of the verb + by + subject of the active sentence.

You use the **Present Perfect** to talk about a finished action or event with present consequences. There is a connection between what happened in the past and the present.

You can use the **Present Perfect passive** to talk about the same kind of actions or events.

The passive shifts the focus from the doer of the action (agent) to the receiver of the action.

Subject + (has or have) + been + past participle

Examples:

- *There is a lot being written about Larry Fine and his witty comedy, sharp tongue, and perfect delivery.*
- *His performance is being touted as the next big star.*
- *Although, this show has been given so many accolades, it represents the lowest form of comedy that exists: cheap laughs at the expense of others.*

